

# **International Academy of Astronautics - SETI Permanent Committee - Annual Meeting Minutes DRAFT**

72<sup>nd</sup> International Astronautical Congress, Dubai World Trade Centre, United Arab Emirates  
Wednesday, October 27, 2021, from 13:00 to 16:00 local time Dubai, Room Fujairah A.

---

In attendance:

Members: Frank Marchis, Jamie Drew, Simon P. (Pete) Worden, Andrew Siemion, Dave MacMahon, Steve Croft, Leonid Gurvits

Guests: Daniel Giles, Kyran Grattan, Dillon O'Reilly, Clare Webb

Attending remotely: Claudio Maccone (outgoing Chair), Michael Garrett, Carol Oliver, Lori Walton, Jill Tarter, Andrea Melis, Les Tennen, Jason Wright, Denise Herzing, Kathryn Denning, Douglas Vakoch, and others

## **1. Welcome**

Michael Garrett welcomed everyone to the meeting and noted that the SETI PC meetings are usually conducted under the auspices of the International Astronautical Congress (IAC), which is organized by the International Astronautical Federation (IAF). The IAF Code of Ethics and Professional conduct was adopted for the meeting

<https://www.iafastro.org/assets/files/static/legal/iaf-code-of-ethics-professional-conduct.pdf>

## **2. Introduction to new SETI PC Executive**

Michael Garrett is the new Chair of the SETI PC. Andrew Siemion and Carol Oliver are the new Co-Chairs, and Lori Walton is the Secretary.

## **3. Minutes of past meetings and this meeting**

Going forward the SETI PC will strive to improve record-keeping.

## **4. Report from the outgoing Chair**

Claudio Maccone summarized his work on the SETI PC. He notes that the international reach of the SETI PC has expanded and the number of members has increased from about 20 back in 2012 to about 100 in 2021. He also noted the importance of Breakthrough Listen and the impacts of discussions regarding UAP's. He will continue his work on mathematical modelling and will devote time to the Moon Farside Legal Protection efforts.

## **4. Commemoration of SETI community members**

Several members of the SETI PC and SETI community passed away since the last in-person meeting in 2019.

- Jill Tarter provided insight into the career of Stu Bowyer and his SETI contributions, including recruiting her into the field of SETI.
- Andrea Melis noted the important role of Nicolo D'Amico in Italian astronomy, the SKA, and in promoting SETI
- Leonid Gurvits provided an overview of the career of Lev Gindilis who advanced the field of radio astronomy in the Soviet Union and was one of the pioneers of Soviet SETI research.
- Michael Garrett noted the passing of three individuals involved in space law; Patricia Sterns, Ernst Fasan, and Elisabeth Back Impallomeni. Claudio Maccone and Les Tennen provided context for the important contributions made by these individuals to the field of SETI. It was noted that Ernst Fasan wrote the seminal book on Metalaw.

## **6. Report from the Incoming Chair**

Michael Garrett reported that updating the SETI PC Terms of Reference (TOR) is an essential task for the SETI PC. All members were encouraged to read the current Terms of Reference, with special consideration to the international

aspect of any detections and activities. He also mentioned the importance of signal detection systems, protection of the lunar environment for future SETI work, publishing of SETI papers, and post-detection work.

**ACTION ITEM:** The SETI PC executive will work to improve communications and the structure of future SETI PC meetings

### **7. Changes to the Terms of Reference for IAA Permanent Committees**

Les Tennen (SETI PC member and member of the IAA Board of Trustees) provided an update on progress being made in updating the Terms of Reference that will apply to all of the various IAA Permanent Committees, including the SETI PC. The expectation is that a new TOR should be adopted at the IAA spring meeting, 2022. Michael Garrett thanked Les Tennen for all his work on this matter.

**ACTION ITEM:** Les Tennen to keep the SETI PC updated on the status of the new Terms of Reference for IAA PC's.

### **8. SETI PC Membership**

Lori Walton and Michael Garrett reported on the discrepancies in the membership lists as recorded by the SETI PC and as recorded by the IAA. Lori Walton has established good communication with the IAA office. She is clarifying the formal process for membership of the SETI PC, including the acceptance of formal letters to be sent out and how the process can be improved upon. Accepting new members awaits an update to the Charter and Terms of Reference. Les Tennen noted that the IAA procedures pertaining to all permanent committees and the membership process are under review by the IAA. It is expected all procedures will become more formalized.

**ACTION ITEM:** Lori Walton to continue coordinating with the IAA as to updating the membership list and membership acceptance procedures

### **9. UAP Working Group Report**

Jason Wright summarized the UAP report (majority and minority). The report was well received by the SETI PC, and everyone appreciated the in-depth and careful analysis. The current SETI PC Terms of Reference exclude any consideration of UAP phenomena. A robust discussion on the report findings followed the presentation of the report's findings. Consideration of UAP studies has implications on the SETI PC standing within the IAA framework. The issue of what to consider in reviewing UAP papers for the IAA SETI annual sessions within the IAC is also of concern. One of the report's recommendations was to conduct a poll of PC members on their position regarding UAP research.

**ACTION ITEM:** The Executive will approach Jason Wright and Kathryn Denning to conduct such a poll.

### **10. Post Detection Working Group Report**

Kathryn Denning presented on Post-detection activities. She noted that a structured working group in this field is needed, particularly given all the global misinformation dissemination on topics including COVID, UAP's, climate, and potential signal detection scenarios from China. She presented a video by Daniela de Paulis, Stelio Montebugnoli, and Andrea Melis describing a project where the Arecibo message was transmitted and received by observatories.

Kathryn Denning introduced John Elliot and described some frustrations on recent difficulties in progressing on post-detection activities under the auspices of the SETI PC (IAA). John Elliot described a UK SETI Research Network (UKSRN) initiative to establish a Post-detection Hub for International Collaboration and Coordination which aims to draw together experts to work on topics ranging from message decipherment and data analytics to development of regulatory protocols, space law and societal impact strategies.

Michael Garrett stressed that the SETI PC Exec considers this area of research to be a critical activity of the SETI PC. The SETI PC has a long history of developing international policy in post-detection protocols/principles and engaging with the full international community that the IAA itself also represents. Andrew Siemion noted that with events such as the BLC1 announcement at the IAC 2021, the international aspect of post-detection is more important than ever. The multi-disciplinary links within the SETI PC are strong, including those actively involved in the technical aspects of the search. Denise Herzing provided an update on the decoding and detecting of non-human communication signals, and Doug Vakoch noted the difficulties in addressing post-detection protocol issues within the SETI PC.

#### **11. IAC 2021 Update**

Andrew Siemion noted good in-person interest in SETI at the IAC 2021, given the pandemic situation. Of particular interest was the high number of younger people interested in SETI. Danny Price reported on the BLC1 observation and follow-up work.

#### **12. IAC 2022**

Michael Garrett reported that a small committee will review the submitted abstracts. The committee will include the session chairs and possibly a member of the Executive.

It was noted that the frequency of PC meetings should be increased to at least twice per year. One meeting could be virtual and one could continue to be the SETI PC meeting at the annual IAC. The idea of “research only” SETI PC meetings was discussed.

#### **13. Other Business**

All present thanked Claudio Maccone for his dedicated years of service as Chair of the SETI PC.